



are meetings of the national security chiefs of BIMSTEC nations. There are mechanisms for forging co-operation in maritime security, cybersecurity and space security as well as a security dialogue and a dialogue among think tanks on regional security.

On disaster management, which comes under security, an expert group has been set up. The group is currently in the process of preparing a 'BIMSTEC Plan of Action to improve Preparedness and Coordination for responding to

Natural Disasters in the Bay of Bengal Region'.

A Climate and Weather Centre has been set up in India. It has been working with the meteorological departments of all the member states to assist them with weather forecasts and forecasts of natural disasters, such as floods, cyclones, and hurricanes.



***The Bay of Bengal also offers vast potential for the blue economy. How are BIMSTEC member states working together to develop and manage***

***their marine resources sustainably?***

The blue economy implies sustainable use of ocean resources for economic growth, improved livelihoods and jobs and sustainable health of the ocean ecosystem. This includes many areas, such as renewable energy, fisheries, climate change, maritime transport, waste management, tourism, etc. In 2023, the BIMSTEC member states decided to include blue economy as a sub-sector for regional co-operation. An expert group to de-

velop a plan of action for regional co-operation on this front has been constituted and is scheduled to meet soon.



***What initiatives are being considered to promote cultural exchange, tourism and academic collaboration among BIMSTEC countries?***

People-to-people contact is one of the core focus areas, with Nepal acting as the lead state. There are specific mechanisms to promote co-operation in culture and tourism. For example, the BIMSTEC Expert Group on Cultural Cooperation met last month in Kathmandu and finalised a plan of action that outlines concrete measures for preserving and promoting tangible and intangible cultural heritages of the member states.

Similarly, the expert group on tourism finalised a plan of action that includes operationalisation of the virtual tourism information centre and the tourism fund. There is also a BIMSTEC network of think tanks. A forum of parliamentarians is being set up and there are plans to promote BIMSTEC youth and media exchanges and organise cultural and film festivals. **BT**

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